

Saint Severus of Antioch
Cathedral Homily 25

HOMILY 25

On Pentecost

Each of the divine solemnities contains a memorial of our redemption and the abolition of one of the judgments that weigh upon humanity—namely, how Christ was born, and how, by his coming in the flesh, he revealed himself to us as the true God. Thus we celebrate the feast on which God becomes manifest, that is, the feast of his manifestation and his birth. For, having been born for the redemption and joy of the whole world, he destroyed the judgment pronounced upon Eve: “In pain you shall bear children” (Genesis 3:16). Moreover, he tasted death in the flesh and put death to death by his own death. And when he rose again, he raised us with him, and we celebrate the memory of his resurrection, which annulled what had been decreed for Adam when he tasted of the tree in transgression of the commandment: “On the day you eat of it, you shall surely die” (Genesis 2:17); and: “You are dust, and to dust you shall return” (Genesis 3:19).

After the resurrection, he ascended into heaven, and the Holy Spirit descended upon us, fifty days having been fulfilled since the day of the resurrection. But he descended, not by exchanging one place for another—for how could he do so, he who fills all things, when the Spirit of the Lord, as it is written, fills the inhabited earth (Wisdom 1:7)?—but by making the action of the divinity known, manifest, and revealed to us. That is why we celebrate the feast of Pentecost,

for through it is abolished the last judgment that the Lord God had decreed for our race, when he was about to bring the flood upon the earth, saying: “My spirit shall not abide in man forever, for they are flesh” (Genesis 6:3).

But this feast of Pentecost was celebrated in figure even among the Hebrews, as Passover was also. Now it was observed in this way: in the days of the harvest, when the sheaf of presentation had been taken and its fruit was ripe, one took a sheaf from the field and raised it before the Lord. But one raised it, not on the very day when it had been taken, but on the following day; and from that point fifty days were counted, and the day when this count was completed was the solemnity, and it was called Pentecost (“Fiftieth”).

But if it also please you to hear the written texts of the law, here is how it stands: “You shall count from the day after the Sabbath; from the day when you have offered the sheaf of presentation, you shall count seven full weeks, until the day after the seventh Sabbath; you shall count fifty days” (Leviticus 23:15–16).

Let us pass, therefore, from the figure to the reality: the sheaf of ears endowed with reason is that of our race—it is Christ, the Word of God who was incarnate for us—for he is our firstfruits, without corruption, just as the first Adam was firstfruits of corruption through the transgression of the commandment. But that this was the first sheaf, the sacred book testifies, expressing itself thus: “And you shall bring a sheaf, firstfruits of your harvest” (Leviticus 23:10). Now Paul calls Christ our firstfruits, saying: “Christ the firstfruits, then those who are Christ’s at his coming” (1 Corinthians 15:23).

This sheaf, therefore, just as the first was composed of ears drawn from the field, was reaped from our race by the cross, voluntary death, and descent into Sheol. But on the next day this sheaf was raised up and sanctified by the resurrection, for our Savior says in the Gospels: “For them I sanctify myself, so that they also may be saints in truth” (John 17:19).

Clinging, therefore, to this ancient figure, we count fifty days, not from the day when the sheaf was reaped, but from the next day—that very day which is the day of the resurrection—or rather, as one who speaks the truth: this ancient figure attaches to the reality, in that the count of the fifty days is not made from the day of the harvest of the sheaf, but from the next day.

May those also be confounded by the figure of this sheaf—those who wander in the divagations of the error of Eutyches and deny that the flesh of our Savior is of the same essence as ours: just as the sheaf is of the same kind and the same essence as the ears in the rest of the field, so too Emmanuel is equal in essence in our flesh to us men, for whom he judged it worthy to be the sheaf and the firstfruits. But do look with me still upon the mystery: he who was represented beforehand by this offering celebrated on this day of Pentecost: “And you shall offer to the Lord, he says, a new oblation. From your dwelling you shall bring loaves of presentation; two loaves of two tenths shall form this single loaf. Leavened loaves shall be baked as firstfruits for the Lord” (Leviticus 23:16–17).

Therefore each loaf that will be offered in oblation is a figure of Emmanuel. For it is he—the bread that came down from heaven and gives life to the world (John 6:51). From two tenths of fine flour a

single loaf results: from the divinity and the humanity that he possesses perfectly, each according to its own notion, for the number ten is the sign of perfection, because this number ten is perfect. Now, on this day of Pentecost, two loaves were offered and not three, to show the revelation of two hypostases—I mean, of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. For the Father is already known beforehand. But when these become known to us, we know one divinity in the Trinity. For whoever honors the Son and the Holy Spirit honors the Father in every way, for it is from him that the Son is, and also the Holy Spirit.

But the fact that leavened loaves are offered shows us yet another symbol. For when we celebrate Passover, it is also the feast of the Passage—for Pascha indeed is translated as “passage”—we have passed, in fact, from the evil bondage of the Slanderer and the demons, through the blood of the Only One, as Israel once did from the tyranny of Pharaoh and the Egyptians and from the plague of him who had caused their firstborn to perish, by that lamb which was sacrificed typologically. They had received the order to offer unleavened bread, since we no longer had anything of the sour and atheistic Egyptian leaven, as Paul also says: “For our Passover also has been sacrificed, Christ, so that we may celebrate the feast, not with the old leaven, nor with a leaven of malice and wickedness, but with unleavened bread of purity and truth” (1 Corinthians 5:7–8). For those who have now come out of malice, renewed, must flee what is old.

But after being redeemed from sin by the blood of Christ and receiving the seed of the Gospel teachings, we received the order to

bring fruit also, therefore to offer leavened loaves at Pentecost, and the sacred book adds the reason, saying: “Leavened loaves shall be baked from the firstfruits for the Lord” (Leviticus 23:17). “Firstfruits,” he says, “is this leaven.” And that is why I do not avert my face from him, for from ancient malice and sourness he frees and preserves it; he makes bread and gives life. Concerning this leaven, our Lord says in the Gospels: “The kingdom of heaven is like leaven which a woman took and hid in three measures of flour, until the whole was leavened” (Matthew 13:33).

But let us consider the figure of Pentecost, if you please, with much more diligence, for the book of the law also says this: “You shall not eat bread, nor roasted new grain, nor baked loaves, before this day, before having brought the offerings of your God” (Leviticus 23:14). It expresses there a perfect teaching—namely, that of the new fruits and seeds of the Gospel, that is, of the bread that nourishes those who are perfect—it is not permitted to eat before the day of Pentecost, that day when the Paraclete came, that Master of perfection.

This too Christ said clearly in the Gospel to his disciples: “I still have many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them now; but when he comes, he, the Spirit of truth, he will lead you into all the truth” (John 16:12–13). Now, what else did he think concerning all the truth, if not the perfect revelation of the Trinity? For we hear Moses and the prophets say of the Father: “Thus says the Lord, the God of Israel”; but we hear the Son show his equality of honor and power with the Father by crying out in the course of his teaching in the Gospel: “It was said to the ancients: You shall not murder; but

whoever murders will be subject to judgment; but I say to you: whoever is angry with his brother without cause will be subject to judgment” (Matthew 5:21–22). Now these words: “But I say to you,” belong to him who is Lawgiver with the power that belongs to God.

But again, concerning the Holy Spirit, the servants of the New Testament were saying in the same way: “This is what the Holy Spirit says,” as it is written in the Acts of the Apostles (Acts 13:2), and also when Paul was writing this to the Galatians concerning him: “But when he willed it, he who from my mother’s womb set me apart and called me by his grace, in order that he might reveal his Son in me, that I might preach him among the Gentiles” (Galatians 1:15–16). In the Acts of the Apostles, likewise, it is written: “While they were celebrating the worship of the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said: Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them” (Acts 13:2). You see that the one whom the Father set apart and called to the service of the Gospel is the same one whom the Holy Spirit set apart and called—not as a servant, but personally, by his own power, as God—which shows that he is of the same essence, glory, and power, on an equality with the Father and the Son.

Therefore, knowing this, when you hear our Savior say in the Gospel concerning the Holy Spirit: “For he will not speak of himself, but whatever he hears he will speak, and he will make known to you the things to come; he will glorify me, for it is from my bounty that he will take and show you” (John 16:13–14), know that it was according to the Economy that he was speaking,

condescending to the weakness of those who heard him, because they could not for the time being understand the revelation of the divinity of the Paraclete and the fact that there is one essence in three hypostases.

One could fear, in fact, that, incapable of rising to the height of these notions, they might represent the Trinity as three separate powers, and give glory to a plurality of powers, not to the unity of power. That is why, with sovereign wisdom, he used these words, saying: “I have many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them now; but when the Spirit of truth comes, he will lead you into all the truth” (John 16:12–13). And he showed that the Paraclete would be the Master of the most perfect knowledge; but at the same time he restrained and attenuated his manner of speaking because of the weakness of those who heard him, saying: “For he will not speak of himself, but whatever he hears he will speak, and it is from my bounty that he will take and show it to you” (John 16:13).

Then, seeing again that by these words he seemed as though to diminish the divine dignity of the Spirit, he immediately established him again, raised him high in the spirit of the disciples, and, after these words, introduced him, saying: “All that is the Father’s is mine; therefore I said: From what is mine he will take and show it to you” (John 16:15). Do not believe, he says, that if the Holy Spirit is to say everything he hears, it is as by instruction or as by revelation from what is greater than he, and that he gives you knowledge, as of what he does not have, by taking it from another.

For just as, he says, I myself am begotten by my Father and all that is the Father’s is mine (John 16:15)—because, being of the same

essence and according to the Economy, I say about myself that I take what is naturally mine—so too, being the Spirit of truth, he who proceeds from the Father (John 15:26), who has by essence what is the Father's, is said to take what is mine. Now what is mine is nothing other than the Father. That is why also, when he was speaking to the Jews, he was mixing these words of the Economy with those of theology, saying: "The Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all" (John 10:29), and again: "I and the Father, we are one" (John 10:30). And indeed, while they could not bear to hear his equality of honor and essence with the Father affirmed, they were going to stone him, saying: "It is not because of good works that we stone you, but because of blasphemy, and because, being a man, you yourself make yourself God" (John 10:33).

Truly important, in fact, is the teaching and proclamation of the holy Trinity, and there is no one among men who could make it known, except the Word of God and the Holy Spirit. That is why also, when he was speaking to Moses, he was saying: "I am the Lord, and I appeared to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob, inasmuch as I am their God; but my name, the Lord, I did not make it known to them" (Exodus 6:3). But what is this name that was not revealed to them, if not that of the uncreated Trinity—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit? Now he clearly said: "I did not make it known to them." What he did not make manifest and known, he showed as through a sign and images, and as far as was possible and worthy of being prefigured and taught—this mystery that was to be revealed.

That is why our Savior was also saying to the Jews: "Abraham your father rejoiced at the thought of seeing my day; he saw it and

rejoiced” (John 8:56). See, therefore, I pray you, the profession and successive elevation of the teaching: starting from the ancient polytheism and cult of the demons of the Egyptians, he was calling the children of Israel to recognize one single and unique God, and he was writing for them a law on tablets of stone. Because he was speaking to them as to people who were as insensible as stones—or rather, as on stones written by God and written with the finger of God, as the divine book says (Exodus 31:18)—he was turning them away from stone gods, insensible ones.

But when they had been prepared for the knowledge of God by the sublime discipline of the law, then the divinity of the Only Word had to be revealed; and he, the God-Word, becoming without change a rational man and frequenting men, makes them progress; he purifies our intelligence weighed down by the passions of the flesh. According to the word of Paul: “So then, in the Spirit we will serve the law of God, and no longer the law of sin in the flesh” (Romans 7:6); and: “There will no longer be condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1); and: “They will walk not according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit” (Romans 8:4), since we are already such, through the coming of the Word in the flesh, that we are raised to a rational and spiritual life, and that we are capable of aiming at the things above (Colossians 3:1–2): the Holy Spirit is revealed to us in a spiritual way, without there being need of the former veil of the flesh.

By tongues of fire he rested upon the apostles, showing by the fire that he is the same in essence and glory as he who in fire descended upon Mount Sinai and set the bush on fire without burning it and

who initiated and instructed Moses; by the tongues, on the other hand, that he is of the lineage of the divinity of the Son and the Word and not a stranger. For tongue and speech have multiple relations with one another and express the movements of the intelligence. When, therefore, the apostles received such grace, when the tongues rested upon them, they began to speak in different tongues and to address speech to the people of the various nations who had come to Jerusalem, the Spirit making known by this that the good news had to be preached equally to all peoples.

But when I reflect on this, I progress still even farther with diligence, because, through the miracle of tongues, the boundless ocean of charity has been manifested to me. For he who came forth from God for our race abolished the ancient debt. But what was the debt? Let us hear the divine books tell it. Divine Moses wrote in the book of Creation in this manner: “And the whole earth was one lip and one voice for all. But as men had moved from the east, they found a plain in the land of Shinar and settled there; and a man said to his neighbor: Come! Let us make bricks and bake them in the fire! Brick served them as stone and bitumen served them as mortar, and they said: Come! Let us build a city and a tower whose top may reach to the heavens! Let us make a name for ourselves, before we are scattered over the face of the whole earth!” (Genesis 11:1–4).

Now the Lord came down to see the city and the tower that the men had built. And the Lord said: “Behold, they all make one people and speak one language, and such is the beginning of their undertakings. Now they will lack nothing of all that they will imagine doing. Come! Let us go down! And there, let us confuse their language, so

that no one will hear anymore the voice of his neighbor!” (Genesis 11:6–8). And the Lord God scattered them from there over the face of the whole earth, and they ceased to build the city and the tower. Thus it was called by the name of Babel, for it is there that the Lord God confused the languages of the whole earth.

This punishment and this division of languages, the Holy Spirit abolished by appearing and manifesting himself in tongues of fire. He abolished them in a manner altogether divine, altogether astonishing, and glorious: not, in fact, that the people of different nations were hearing the apostles speak a single language, but, on the contrary, those who were speaking were using many languages as of one; and those who were listening condescended to let themselves be persuaded, without contesting, by the preaching of the Gospel. If in fact he had again made the language of all men one, assent to the preaching would have seemed to be rather a matter of constraint and not of persuasion.

But while through many and diverse languages one faith was being proclaimed, the free will of those who have believed is demonstrated, while the confusion of languages of old is healed by the agreement of the proclamation. The struggle with God of those men of old had caused the division of the language of the whole earth, which was one; but the knowledge of God gathered the different languages into one faith, and, in the manner of the strings of a lyre that produce different sounds, prepared for the one who plays it a single melodious song, and fulfilled the prophecy of Zechariah who cries out: “The Lord will be as king over all the earth; on that day there will be one Lord and his sole name that goes

throughout all the earth” (Zechariah 14:9).

That is why I was saying, at the beginning of the homily, that every feast, so to speak, was the abolition of the judgments that weigh upon our race. Such are the gifts and others like them that the manifest coming of the Paraclete brings us; and, as we have been enriched by the coming in the flesh of God the Word, we have also merited a certain mystical coming of the Spirit, so to speak spiritual and incorporeal, from him who has also poured out upon us his own gifts like dew. Concerning this Paul, in enumerating them, was saying: “To one has been given through the Spirit a word of wisdom; to another a word of knowledge in the same Spirit; to another faith in this same Spirit; to another gifts of healing in that one Spirit; to another working of miracles; to another prophecy; to another discernment of spirits; to another diversities of tongues; to another the gift of interpreting them; but all this, it is the one and same Spirit who works it, distributing to each in particular as he wills” (1 Corinthians 12:8–11).

You see the richness of the superabundance of the gift well worthy of God, and the power of this Spirit who distributes by his own will, to each, as he wills, the divine gifts. How then do you claim that the Spirit is not God, and do you reduce to the plane of creatures him who is uncreated—the author of the servant and heavenly powers—and, for us men, not only our creator, but also the giver of all wisdom and intelligence? For David says: “By the word of the Lord the heavens were firmly set, and by the Spirit of his mouth all their host” (Psalm 33:6).

But someone, as a philosopher, says in the book of Job: “The divine Spirit made me, and the breath of the Almighty instructed me” (Job 33:4). God the Word has thus manifested himself in us who live on earth, when he humbled himself and, without change, became man, and when he accomplished the Economy in a calm and peaceful manner, according to the prophecy of Isaiah saying: “He will not contend and will not cry out, and no one will hear his voice in the streets; he will not crush the bruised reed, nor extinguish the wick that still smokes” (Isaiah 42:2–3). Having thus frequented men as a man, he endured in the flesh voluntarily the cross for us; he alone tasted the death that gives life; he raised us with him, we who were dead, because he is the firstfruits of the resurrection. In honor of this lofty deed and of such help, during these fifty days we do not kneel on the ground in our prayers in any way, but, standing and upright, we spread out our hands, praising the one who was crucified, buried, and risen; and, against our enemies, the Slanderer and the demons, with David we sing: “They bend and they fall; but we, we are standing and upright” (Psalm 20:7–8).

But as the Holy Spirit, in a manner worthy of God, manifested himself and appeared to us, and that the divinity through tongues of fire enlightened us and poured out the abundant richness of his spiritual gifts—for he says in fact: “I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh” (Joel 2:28)—as before him whose sight we cannot bear and who stupefies us by the greatness of the superabundance of his gifts, we bow down toward the earth and bow on our knees, glorifying the giver of these gifts which are so great.

Furthermore, since we are purified by fasting and have set aright our spiritual life, it is customary for those who are worthy of divine visions to kneel on the ground and proclaim by this attitude the sublimity and grandeur of the vision. This is what the disciples experienced when the outward appearance of Jesus was transformed on the mountain and he showed somewhat of the radiance of his divinity: for, says the evangelist, they fell on their face and were altogether afraid (Matthew 17:6).

Certainly the tongues of fire threw them into turmoil and astonished them in their spirits, but they did not in any way allow themselves to kneel on the ground, so that one might well see these tongues that had settled upon each of them.

But we, in their place, here is what we do: in bowing on our knees we tremble before the Majesty of the divine coming of the Spirit; we adore and praise him as Lord and God; but at the same time we show that through the Spirit we have learned perfect worship, which begins with the Father and which ends in the Spirit, which has its term and ends in him; for everything that is outside these three hypostases is not worthy of worship, but is instituted for those who worship: the property, in fact, of uncreated and timeless divinity is to be worshipped in spirit and in truth, because God is Spirit, and those who worship him—it is in spirit and in truth that they must worship him (John 4:24).

That is why, in fact, this Holy Spirit is also called Paraclete (John 14:16)—that is, intercessor—because he dwells in our hearts, because he incites and presses us toward what is best and teaches us not only to worship, but also to pray in the Spirit. Hence also Paul,

writing to the Romans, was saying: “For we do not know what prayer to make as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with inexpressible groanings” (Romans 8:26).

Let us not cease to practice this at all times, but let us show a pure life; and, in venerating these tongues of fire, let us turn our faces away from pagan defilements, from blasphemy, from demented and foolish words, and that, through divine words, it may burn and baptize our tongue; let us not defile it with mud through earthly words, but that it may be in festivity each day thanks to the things of heaven, and that it may praise the one God in the holy Trinity, to whom is glory and power for the ages. Amen!